

Pre-emptive feedback

And some advice

Reason for slides...

- There are common problems to many assignments
- Read this now and again at least a week before you submit
(or just ignore this and take your chances)
- Avoid the errors, get good marks, an excellent degree, a top job with a salary beyond your dreams... (you may need to do additional work like actually complete the assignment as well)

General info

- 4 main points:
 - Plagiarism - Cut/paste (not the same thing)
 - Formatting / layout
 - Abstracts
 - Referencing
- Other comment
 - Time for research
 - Depth of research
 - Following Instructions!!

Plagiarism, similarity, cut and paste

- You will have been given other information
- There are statements on the assignments
- Plagiarism is not just repeating the words of someone else.
 - Claiming or appearing to claim responsibility for something
 - Rewording a concept does not avoid plagiarism
 - It is like a patent for concepts
 - “Similarity” can show similarity – a few added words just shows up in the middle of a block of similar text
 - You are not learning or understanding cut and paste text (and it takes a long time to try to make it look like you didn’t cut and paste)

Plagiarism, similarity, cut and paste

- You must reference your sources
- If you are quoting ☹, make sure you make it clear (pictures / diagrams are quotes too)
- Do not copy or reword someone else's work and think that a reference makes it acceptable, it is the academic equivalent of theft (and then justifying it by saying where you stole it from)
- If you are accused of plagiarism you are in serious trouble, if it is proven (and it is nearly impossible to defend against), you will probably lose your place on the course and lose any existing marks

Avoiding Plagiarism? – easy, do your own work!

- Use a reference to any other work to say “This has been done, I am building on it” or “This is similar but not the same as the thing that I am doing” or “This is a foundation work for this subject”
 - This says that you have researched, you have read about the subject, you have understood it and you think you can do better
- Use a reference to any other work to support your findings
 - Do an experiment, obtain a result and then state if others in the field found the same results (be careful, this means it is not your work but it does justify theirs)
- Use a reference to any other work to support your view (especially when it cannot be proven)
 - New scientific research is based on notions, ideas, theories – there are no facts before you prove it.

Avoiding Plagiarism? – easy, acknowledge others!

- Use a reference to dispute someones argument
 - This says that you recognise that there are few undisputable “facts” and are willing to consider many views
- Use a reference to justify the comment / figure you used to expand your work
 - This says your work acknowledges the work of someone else and is reliant on their integrity

Formatting

- Use the format provided. Take a copy first
 - Italics
 - Bold
 - Justified!!!

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Abstract

- Written at the **very end** and inserted at the beginning
- Written as if you have read the paper for the first time and are writing a summary
 - Like the sleeve notes on a book or film but including all of the “spoilers” (who did it, was there really a ghost, where was the jewel?)
- <https://www.wikihow.com/Write-an-Abstract>

Referencing

- Use the built in MS Word bibliography
- TAKE THE BIBLIOGRAPHY WITH YOU!
 - Builds up over time
- There are other tools (free, paid, cloud based, local)
 - Mendeley
- Choose the right style from the dropdown box
- Insert the References table at the end (delete or change the title)
- Formatting in two columns is difficult – narrow the entire table before trying to make the first column wider.

Time for research, report, depth of research

- This should have been the culmination of many weeks of learning
- This should have been you conducting research, not just stating what you already (think that you) know
- Do not repeat back to me whatever I told you, find something more!
- Plan to get finished in advance of the deadline (you will over-run, you know you will!)

Following instruction

- The instructions are clear – read them! follow them!
 - Do not do something that you wish had been asked for
 - Do not decide what should have been asked for
 - Do not consider what could have been asked for
-
- I am always willing to consider how an assignment could be improved for next years intake, it will not change this assignment

Finally (to prove I am human - or not)

- If the whole world is conspiring against you to prevent you completing on time, talk to me.
- The EEC system is there for a reason
- This is tough, I know it
- Do not look for sympathy (or an extended hand in) if you failed to start on time, misread the hand in date, had to go out with mates, felt a bit tired, overslept, etc.